

Chthulucene

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1 PROJECT URL

<https://www.jiabaoli.org/chthulucene>

2 DESCRIPTION OF ARTWORK

Since the beginning of the British Industrial Revolution, Humans have become an important force affecting the evolution of the environment. Scientists call it the "Anthropocene", which summarizes the geological changes from this period. But after realizing the role of mankind, we once again placed ourselves at the center of the world. In this project, we try to imagine a world where human beings are not the only important actors in the world. Diverse species are intertwined and react upon each other.

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On the evolutionary tree, humans and octopuses separated 500 million years ago. And they evolved distributed intelligence into a completely different extreme than humans. What if the world is not centered around humans but octopuses?

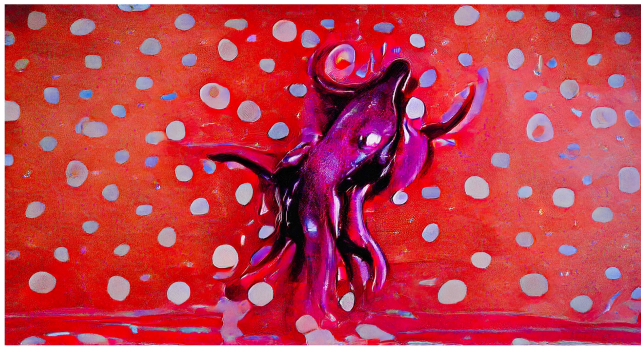
We imagine a world where global warming causes sea levels to rise and all continents are submerged underwater. As a highly intelligent species in the ocean, the octopuses have unlocked the optic gland gene that releases self-destructing hormones after giving birth. Now they can pass on the wisdom of their ancestors from generation to generation.

The "Anthropocene" ends, and the earth enters the "Chthulucene."

When humans are on the edge of extinction due to environmental breakdown, how can we design an elegant extinction? What can we create so that the upcoming species, in this case, the octopus, will remember us with a little bit of tenderness and empathy?

In the first attempt, we try to connect with octopuses through learning their movements, through interspecies metamorphosis. Shifting from human supremacy worldview to a world where we have to adapt and learn the becoming of other species; shifting from the central governed brain to distributed intelligence; shifting our visual dominated senses to tactile perception.

We also wonder what this world would be like through the octopus's perception. Maybe there are Bioengineered humans with enlarged organs specialized in their functions to adapt and survive



underwater. Maybe Territorial birds will take advantage of their aerial ability when the land is underwater. Maybe there are Octopus archeologists scanning through the remnants of the Anthropocene. You might know that Each of octopus' tentacle can think on its own. Here are three octopuses expressing their opinions. It's hard because the tentacles from the same octopus may disagree with each other.

Human-centric thinking has caused irreversible environmental disasters and numerous species to become extinct. Every 9 minutes, one species on this planet disappears... forever. As the human impact on Earth's ecosystems, the Anthropocene, rampages, our challenge for the next decade will be to reimagine how we live through the lens of the environment; to shift our perspectives from human-centered, EGO-centric, profit-driven post-industrialist thinking to a multi-species, ECO-centric worldview. This requires a fundamental perception change, rewiring our views of nature and hierarchies of intelligence.

From western religions, we've been indoctrinated for thousands of years to believe ourselves to be the only species with souls. Philosophers like Descartes famously thought that animals were merely 'automata' without experiences - Implying a hierarchy of intelligence and justifying the anthropocentric view of animals and nature.

Many of our preconceived notions about our human exceptionalism are being challenged thanks to new scientific research – animals form lifelong bonds across species, design and build architectural wonders, coordinate construction plans across entire continents, learn and speak to each other's languages, invent tools, and pass lessons on from generation to generation.

There are numerous types of intelligence beyond human intelligence, such as distributed intelligence of octopuses, swarm intelligence of ants, bees, and birds, collective intelligence of mycelium, and microbial intelligence. Co-create with non-human species helps us probe into different intelligences, shift perspectives, and interrogate ourselves.

If the entire world is a projection of our perception, how do we see the world from a cephalopod's perspective? What can we create from that perspective? What can we co-design together with and for them? To collaborate, we need to go beyond passive looking and deeply understand the non-human intelligence, behavior, and agency. We need to respect, learn, connect, share the *umwelt*, exchange senses, embody and be like each other. Finding connections reveals how we are part of many continuums of intelligences.

3 ARTIST INFORMATION

Jiabao Li Jiabao Li creates works addressing climate change, interspecies co-creation, humane technology, and perceptions. Her mediums include wearable, robot, AR/VR, performance, scientific experiment, installation. In Jiabao's TED Talk, she uncovered how technology mediates the way we perceive reality. Jiabao is a Tenure Track Assistant Professor at The University of Texas at Austin. Her lab explores the intersection of art, design, technology, and biology. She graduated from Harvard GSD with Distinction and thesis award. Jiabao is the recipient of numerous awards, including Forbes China 30 Under 30, iF Design Award, Falling Walls, NEA, STARTS Prize, Fast Company, Core77, IDSA, A' Design Award, Webby Award, Cannes World Film Festival Best VR short Award. Her work has been exhibited internationally, at Venice Architecture Biennale, MoMA, Ars Electronica, Today Art Museum Biennial, SIGGRAPH, Milan and Dubai Design Week, Ming Contemporary Museum, ISEA, Anchorage Museum, OCAT Contemporary Art Terminal, CHI, Museum of Design, Alaska State Museum. Her work has been featured on Fast Company, Art Forum, Business Insider, Bloomberg, Yahoo, South China Morning Post, TechCrunch, Domus, Yanko Design, Harvard Political Review, The National, Leonardo, Exceptional ALIEN.

Credits: Concept and Direction: Jiabao Li. Producers: Jiabao Li, Mareva Minerbi. Choreography and performance: Mareva Minerbi, Sheenru Yong, Theo Steinman. Music: Lu Wang dk. Editor: Dónal Foreman. Cinematographer: Vincent Bercasio. Illustrator: Aemon Cannon. Octopus Synthesist: Steven Wilkinson. Drone Videographer: Pat Galvin. Shepherd: Cooper Galvin.